Admiral of the Swiss Navy

By Sam Lipsyte

NARRATOR: I can't remember the name of the camp. It was somewhere near a lake near Canada. That summer some of us used to go smoke cigarettes behind the Port-O-Sans. Mr. Marv caught us one time, wanted to make a point.

Mr. Marv wore swim togs and parted his hair like a magician. They said he was a teacher of history in the winter somewhere. That summer, though, he was just Mr. Marv, blitzed at the bonfire, babbling on about the time he was a kid and sneaked into a ball game.

He was going to send us packing, which I guess is not a big deal looking back, but at the time it was seen as a stain. Plus, to have your dad drive up in that sad kind of station wagon. What I did was give Mr. Marv some of the names he needed. I gave him the names of boys you've never heard of but who were known saboteurs of good camp citizenship. I'm not sorry I did

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it, either. If I saw those boys today, I'd say, "You brought it on yourselves."

INTRODUCTION

Summer break – A time to relax from the rigors of school and re-connect with nature. For many students this may mean summer camp. Fresh air, new friends, and new social dynamics. For self-assured teens, this may be true and the experience will create memories and friendships that will last a lifetime. But for others, the ones that find themselves to be the "Odd Camper Out" – the experience can be a traumatic ordeal.

There is a fine line between "boys will be boys" and toxic bullying. And sometimes that line becomes a matter of life or death. You see, no matter what people say . . . the victim NEVER brings it on himself.

The Admiral of the Swiss Navy by Sam Lipsyte

NARRATOR: Van Wort was the fat kid who put our camp all over the local news that summer, and if you were watching TV back then, you might have caught my debut. I was the one standing in the dining hall saying, "He brought it on himself."

I don't think I believed that, even then, but I guess I wanted to say something memorable, something

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beyond my years. I could have said what a terrible tragedy it all was, but Mr. Marv seemed to be in charge of that part.

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NARRATOR: I slept next to Van Wort. I listened to the air whistle in and out of his fat chest. He said he had a chronic bronchial. He said it like a lie he made up a long time ago.

I watched them come to him night after night, boys with their mosquito sprays, their shampoos, tennis rackets and combs, warm water in toothbrush cups. Van Wort was fat and his name was Van Wort. With that combination, why would you pack your kid off to camp? Let him play with ladybugs in the safety of his own lawn.

The counselor tortured Van Wort, too. He was just a mean kid with more years on him, more muscles. His name was Steve, or maybe Ivan. Steve-Ivan called Van Wort Van Wort Hog. Or Fat S***, for short. He was the one who told us to piss in Van Wort's

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canteen. It was the best canteen in the bunk, brand new, fuzzy wool, a cavalry sleeve. We took turns pissing in it and dipping it down in the Port-O-San hole. We left it under his short-sheeted bed.

When he found it, his eyes went dark, his great arms started wibbling, wobbling on his knees. The canteen, he told us, was a gift from his dead father.

STEVE-IVAN: It's just a joke you fat s***. We're your friends.

VAN WORT: *(wanting to believe)* Really?

STEVE-IVAN: Sure. Just don't be a Van Wort Hog and run crying to Mr. Marv.

NARRATOR: Van Wort stopped crying and he didn't run but he went to see Mr. Marv. Steve-Ivan was somebody's cousin near Canada, though. The whole thing blew, as they say, over.

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NARRATOR: We did a camp-wide Capture-the-Flag. I wasn't in Van Wort's unit, but I can tell you things got pretty hairy out there. What happened to this one girl in the beet field was a shame. We never did know

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what the rules were, or which kids were still living or dead. My unit just marauded around. We laid waste to Mr. Marv's azaleas and tied a boy to the tetherball pole. Then we lucked into view of the flag, this dinky fluorescent thing, planted on a hill. We flew up along a ridge near the tennis courts. Van Wort appeared out of nowhere with a croquet mallet in his hands. Some of us batted the mallet away and beat Van Wort to the dirt. I led the rest of them. I didn't want to know what they were doing to Van Wort [because] . . . victory equaled a sack of candy bars, to be divided evenly among all living members of our unit.

Van Wort spent the night in the infirmary, though a boy who was there for a spider bite said there were no visible marks.

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NARRATOR: We played Freeze-Please every breakfast, lunch, and dinner. Steve-Ivan would say "Freeze, Please" while we were eating and we'd all go stone-cold statue. Whoever moved first was Admiral of the Swiss Navy, which meant you had to scrape and stack

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the dishes, bus them over to the kitchen. The Swiss have no navy, but who knew that then?

We called Van Wort the Commodore because he couldn't hold still. I think it was unfair, really, because it wasn't so much him as his fat that was moving, if that makes any sense at all. Study a fat kid hard and it might.

STEVE-IVAN: Well, it looks like another lucky day for the Hog.

NARRATOR: "I'll help him," I said. Everyone gawked, as though I'd been struck with sudden bolts of lightning, but it was just this feeling I had, that Van Wort was getting a bad break. He wasn't so off. He wasn't even weird. It wasn't like he wrote bird poems or wore the wrong kind of underwear.

VAN WORT: Why are you doing this?

NARRATOR: Just because.

VAN WORT: I don't care what you do to me. If it's a trick, it's a trick.

NARRATOR: We were quiet and stacked for a while. *(to Van Wort)* So, who killed your dad?"

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VAN WORT: Nobody killed him. He dropped dead. I saw it. He went blue and had a bubble on his mouth.

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NARRATOR: Each night they came to his bed where he lay wheezing. It wasn't even foot powder and Indian burns anymore. They wanted to hurt him, to make him bleed. They taped him down to the bed frame, went at it with tweezers and pocketknives. They got his sock bunched up for a ball gag. They pinched off pieces of him with nail clippers and tiny sewing shears from kits their mothers had packed.

I'd get up and walk to the other end of the bunk until they were done. In the morning I'd help him clean up, wipe down the blood until it was just dark nicks. We talked about everything except what they did to him.

He told me he had given the eulogy at his father's funeral, that it was easy, he'd just used an essay he'd written for school and substituted "my father" for "our founding fathers."

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I started to admire Van Wort. But then I'd hate him for being so weak. He'd given up even the shrieking and they rarely bothered to gag him anymore. (to Van Wort) Why don't you fight back?.

VAN WORT: What's the point?

NARRATOR: The point is you show them you're not a *wussy.* Then they leave you alone.

VAN WORT: Will you help me?

NARRATOR: No. That would be wrong.

VAN WORT: Why?

NARRATOR: It's complicated.

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NARRATOR: Then it was the last day of camp. We packed all our stuff in duffels. Tomorrow we would strip our beds and get into our family wagons, wave.

At our last lunch Steve-Ivan said that Van Wort and I would be voted camp love-birds at the camp banquet that night. *(to Steve-Ivan)* Vote us whatever you want.

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We had to stack without even a Freeze-Please and Van Wort wouldn't look at me. *(to Van Wort)* What's wrong with you?

VAN WORT: I'm done with this.

NARRATOR: I took that to mean that he was going to do something, make himself the last of the brave. What he meant, though, was that he was truly done.

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NARRATOR: Van Wort took a canoe out to the middle of the lake. We were doing free swim and we heard him call to us, watched him drink from a big plastic jug and just sort of bend over, roll off the bow into the lake. You'd figure drowning would be hard going to begin with, but picture it with your guts burning off from a stolen jug of kitchen lye. Steve-Ivan dove in to save him but Van Wort was too fat. We watched them bob together in the middle of the lake. Then Steve-Ivan was bobbing up and down alone. He swam back weeping, or maybe it was the water.

They got Van Wort's body out with a special boat. They had him in a strap swinging off the gunwale. His

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swim trunks trailed out from his feet and you could see all the night wounds on him.

MR. MARV: Self-mutilation. Interesting.

NARRATOR: The news trucks drove up that afternoon. Van Wort's father appeared, too. He was a skinny man in a sun hat. He stood on the shoreline shouting at no one in particular. I walked up to him. *(To VW's Father)* I was his friend.

FATHER: Were you his Judas, too? *(slaps narrator across the face, then immediately regrets it)* I didn't mean that. I know you were his friend. Bobby wrote me about you.

NARRATOR: *(long pause)* I had long forgotten Van Wort was also a Bobby, if I ever knew. . . . I was his friend, [and] I was the one standing in the dining hall saying, "He brought it on himself." . . . . his friend.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Sam Lipsyte
Book: Venus Drive: Stories
ISBN: 978-0312429607
Publisher: Picador
Date (Month/Year): March 2010

AWARD HISTORY

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